

Cobalt Ridge Consulting Group

Corporate Profile & Capability Overview — FY2026 Edition

1. Who We Are

Cobalt Ridge Consulting Group (CRCG) is a mid-market management and technology consultancy founded in 2011 by Desmond Okafor, a former operations executive at a Fortune 500 industrial manufacturer. CRCG was built on a simple premise: that most operational transformation programs fail not for lack of strategy, but for lack of disciplined execution. Today, CRCG is led by Chief Executive Officer Renata Albescu, who joined the firm in 2014 as a partner and assumed the CEO role in January 2020. The firm's tagline, "Operational clarity. Measurable change.," reflects its focus on outcomes that can be tracked, audited, and defended in a boardroom.

As of the publication of this profile (Q1 FY2026), CRCG employs approximately 184 consulting and corporate staff across five offices: Chicago, Illinois (headquarters); Austin, Texas; Denver, Colorado; Toronto, Ontario; and a satellite office in London, United Kingdom that opened in the second half of 2023 to support European expansion of existing North American clients. Headcount figures fluctuate throughout the fiscal year due to project-based staffing and should be read as a point-in-time snapshot rather than a fixed organizational size; see the FY2025 Financial Summary for year-end headcount.

2. Mission and Operating Principles

- **Evidence before opinion.** Every recommendation is grounded in client data, not industry templates copy-pasted from prior engagements.
- **Skin in the game.** A meaningful share of engagement fees on Strategic-tier accounts are structured around milestone achievement rather than time-and-materials alone.
- **Small senior teams.** CRCG deliberately avoids large junior-staff pyramids; engagement teams are kept lean and partner-involved throughout delivery, not just at sales.
- **Knowledge transfer is mandatory.** Every Statement of Work includes a defined capability hand-off plan so that client teams can sustain improvements after CRCG exits.

3. Practice Areas

CRCG organizes its consulting capability into four practice areas, each led by a senior partner who is accountable for methodology quality, staffing, and engagement economics within that line.

Practice Area	Practice Lead	Description
Operations Excellence	Priya Natarajan	Process redesign, lean operations, supply chain resilience, plant-floor digitization, and continuous improvement programs.
Digital & Analytics	Samuel Kestrel	Data strategy, interoperability, predictive analytics, digital twins, and platform modernization.

Practice Area	Practice Lead	Description
Risk & Compliance	Tobias Lindqvist	Operational risk frameworks, regulatory readiness, internal controls, and audit remediation.
People & Change	Rowan Mackeson	Organizational design, change management, workforce transition planning, and capability building.

4. Industries Served

While CRCG accepts engagements opportunistically across sectors, the firm has built deep, repeatable methodology assets in six priority verticals: Manufacturing, Healthcare & Life Sciences, Retail & Consumer Goods, Energy & Utilities, Financial Services, Public Sector. Roughly 64% of FY2025 engagement revenue was concentrated in Manufacturing and Healthcare & Life Sciences combined, reflecting CRCG's historical roots in industrial operations consulting and its more recent expansion into regulated healthcare data programs following the 2021 hire of Samuel Kestrel to lead the Digital & Analytics practice.

5. Client Portfolio Snapshot

CRCG maintains a portfolio of approximately 40 active and recently-active client relationships at any given time. The following table highlights six representative accounts referenced throughout CRCG's case study library and project documentation. Account tiering (Strategic, Growth, Standard) determines service level commitments, executive sponsorship cadence, and minimum quarterly business review frequency.

Client	Industry	Tier	Client Since
Atlas Manufacturing Co.	Manufacturing	Strategic	2019-03-11
NovaHealth Systems	Healthcare & Life Sciences	Strategic	2021-07-22
Brightline Retail Group	Retail & Consumer Goods	Growth	2020-01-15
Helios Energy Partners	Energy & Utilities	Strategic	2022-09-05
Meridian Trust Bank	Financial Services	Growth	2023-02-14
City of Beaumont Public Works	Public Sector	Standard	2023-11-30

6. Leadership Team

CRCG's leadership bench combines long-tenured operators with specialists recruited from industry and from larger consultancies. Brief leadership biographies are provided below; full professional profiles for senior and mid-level staff are maintained separately in the firm's Team Member Profiles document.

Renata Albescu — Chief Executive Officer. Renata joined CRCG in 2014 as a partner in the Operations Excellence practice after eight years at a global industrial conglomerate, where she led a 200-person plant operations function. She was named CEO in January 2020 and has since overseen the firm's expansion into Digital & Analytics and Risk & Compliance as standalone practice areas.

Desmond Okafor — Founder & Chairman. Desmond stepped back from day-to-day CEO duties in 2020 but remains active in firm governance, major-account sponsorship (including Atlas Manufacturing Co., CRCG's longest-tenured client), and recruiting of senior partners.

Naomi Tran — VP, Finance & Controller. Naomi has led CRCG's finance function since 2017 and is responsible for engagement economics reporting, billing rate governance, and the firm's annual financial summary published each spring for internal and board distribution.

Rowan Mackeson — VP, People & Talent. Rowan leads recruiting, performance management, and the People & Change practice's internal capability programs, and co-authored CRCG's current Code of Conduct, last revised in March 2025.

7. Office Locations

Office
Chicago, IL (HQ)
Austin, TX
Denver, CO
Toronto, ON
London, UK (satellite, opened 2023)

Headquarters: 1420 Lakeshore Drive, Suite 900, Chicago, IL 60601. General inquiries should be directed through www.cobaltridgeconsulting.com or routed via the client's assigned account lead.

8. Awards and Recognition

- Named to the regional “Best Mid-Size Firms to Work For” list by the Chicago Business Journal in 2023 and 2024.
- Helios Energy Grid Asset Digital Twin Roadmap (PRJ-2355) received an honorable mention at the 2024 North American Energy Innovation Awards.
- Samuel Kestrel was recognized as a “40 Under 40 Consulting Leader” by Consulting Quarterly Magazine in 2023.